Backdoor in Claude Code for VS Code extension on the Cursor Marketplace

Source: Hacker News

The Brief

What shipped
Phorion reported a backdoored release of the Claude Code for VS Code extension, version 2.1.313, on the Cursor Marketplace.

Capabilities
The injected code runs when the extension module loads and attempts to add an attacker-controlled SSH public key, configure SSH access, and create a reverse SSH tunnel to 134.209.82[.]225. The write-up describes persistence logic for macOS, Linux, and Windows; it says the macOS SSH-enablement check can fail for standard users and the Windows service-setup path appears buggy.

Availability
Cursor removed the affected release from its marketplace, and the 2.1.313 NPM and VS Code versions were also pulled from their registries. Current availability of other versions is not stated.

Why it matters
Check developer environments for use of version 2.1.313 and engage incident response if found. Because the payload runs on module load with the IDE user's permissions, review extension artifacts and relevant SSH configuration, including authorized_keys; the write-up advises checking the public-key fingerprint rather than relying only on the svc-telemetry comment.

Caveats
The article text is truncated during its description of the reverse tunnel, so it does not provide the full persistence, beaconing, or detection details. The reported macOS flaw can prevent SSH enablement on machines where Remote Login is off, but does not prevent key installation or ensure the backdoor is harmless if SSH is already enabled.

Full Announcement Details

Phorion has detected a backdoor in the official Claude Code for VS Code extension bundle on the Cursor Marketplace that drops a persistent SSH backdoor across macOS, Linux, and Windows. This write-up focuses primarily on macOS, where the extension

attempts to configure an SSH backdoor and establish persistence.

Organisations should immediately review their environments for use of Claude Code for VSCode 2.1.313 and engage incident response where use of the extension is discovered.

Phorion has discovered a compromise of the official Claude Code for VS Code extension on the Cursor Marketplace, where the backdoored extension bundle contains a persistent Secure Shell (SSH) backdoor. Cursor has removed the associated release from its marketplace, additionally pulling NPM and VSCode versions for 2.1.313 from their relevant registries.

While the implant includes setup and persistence logic for macOS, Linux, and Windows , we're going to focus primarily on macOS in this post, calling out the key differences and a few implementation bugs on the other platforms along the way.

The Cursor Marketplace serves extensions for the Cursor editor. Because extensions run with the permissions of the IDE and the user running it, a backdoored extension gets immediate access to local files, source code, and developer tooling as soon as its module is loaded.

Notably, Phorion has discovered a likely oversight in how the malware tries to turn on SSH. The setup logic assumes it can check the current Remote Login state without root privileges. When run as a standard user, systemsetup -getremotelogin prints an administrator-access error and exits with status 0 instead of returning Off . Because the script only tries to enable SSH if the output matches Off , it skips the enablement step entirely. On a Mac that doesn't already have SSH running, that mistake breaks the inbound access path, even though the SSH keys and persistence still get dropped.

In this post, we'll walk through how the backdoor works, why that macOS check fails, and what to look for across your fleet. The goal of this payload is long-term interactive access, and whilst the SSH backdoor bug minimises impact on macOS, the malware is still a significant threat that installs persistence and beacons host reconnaissance back to the operator.

Infection Chain

The Cursor Marketplace Extension

The compromised extension.js file starts with an injected immediately invoked function expression (IIFE) prepended to the minified extension bundle. The rest of the bundle looks like the standard extension, with Claude Code and VS Code strings, normal activate and deactivate exports, and UI code.

The injected prefix pulls in standard Node.js modules (child_process , fs , os , path , http , and crypto) and executes as soon as Node loads the file, before the extension's normal activate callback even runs. The user doesn't need to interact with the extension for the payload to fire.

Stage 1 - Preparing SSH Access

First, the payload...

Want to learn more?

https://phorion.io/blog/offical-claude-code-vsx-compromise/

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